Bonus · Reading Language Arts Challenge Test

Read each passage, then answer the questions that follow. Use evidence from the texts.

An extra reading test for one more round of practice. Mark answers on blank paper; write SCR and ECR responses on lined paper.

Passage 1 — The Last Lap (fiction)

(1) Diego's legs burned as he rounded the final turn. Three runners were ahead of him, and the finish line seemed impossibly far.

(2) He thought about quitting. His lungs ached; his side cramped. No one would blame him for slowing down—he was only in eighth grade, and this was the district final.

(3) Then he heard it: his little sister's voice in the crowd, shouting his name. She had watched him train every morning before dawn, timing his laps with their mother's old stopwatch.

(4) Something shifted. Diego lengthened his stride. One runner fell behind, then another. His legs found a rhythm he did not know he had.

(5) He did not win—he crossed the line in second place. But as he bent over, gasping, his sister threw her arms around him. "You passed two people!" she cried.

(6) Diego smiled through the pain. He had not come in first, but he had given everything he had. Some races, he realized, you win just by not giving up.

1. "The finish line seemed *impossibly far*" shows that Diego felt it was — A. easy to reach B. very hard to reach C. right in front of him D. behind him

2. What makes Diego push harder? — A. the coach B. his sister's voice C. the weather D. a trophy

3. "Something shifted" suggests that Diego — A. gave up B. found new motivation C. stopped running D. was injured

4. A theme of the story is that — A. winning is all that matters B. effort and perseverance matter C. running is easy D. crowds are loud

5. At the end, Diego's feelings are best described as — A. bitter B. proud despite not winning C. angry D. bored

6. Which line **best** shows Diego's determination? — A. "He thought about quitting" B. "Diego lengthened his stride" C. "the finish line seemed impossibly far" D. "his lungs ached"

7. "His legs found a rhythm" is an example of — A. simile B. personification C. hyperbole D. irony

SCR 1. *(2 points)* How does Diego change during the race? Support your answer with **evidence from the text.**

Passage 2 — The Clever Octopus (informational)

(1) The octopus may be the smartest animal without a backbone. These sea creatures can solve puzzles, use tools, and even recognize individual people.

(2) An octopus has about 500 million neurons—more than a rabbit. Strangely, two-thirds of them are not in its brain but in its eight arms. Each arm can taste, touch, and make decisions almost on its own.

(3) Octopuses are famous escape artists. In aquariums, they have opened jars, squeezed through tiny gaps, and sneaked out of tanks at night to hunt. One octopus learned to unscrew a jar lid to reach a crab inside.

(4) They also protect themselves cleverly. An octopus can change color and texture in an instant to blend into rocks or coral, and it can squirt ink to confuse a predator.

(5) Scientists are still learning how such a different kind of mind works. The octopus reminds us that intelligence can take many surprising forms.

8. The central idea of the passage is that octopuses are — A. dangerous B. surprisingly intelligent C. always in jars D. animals with backbones

9. As used in paragraph 3, "escape artists" suggests octopuses are good at — A. painting B. getting out of tight spaces C. swimming fast D. making ink

10. Paragraph 2 is mainly organized by — A. telling a story B. giving facts about the octopus's nervous system C. comparing colors D. listing dangers

11. Which detail **best** supports the idea that octopuses use tools? — A. "change color" B. "learned to unscrew a jar lid" C. "squirt ink" D. "500 million neurons"

12. From paragraph 2, you can infer that an octopus's arms — A. are useless B. can act with some independence C. cannot move D. are its only brain

13. The author's purpose is to — A. persuade you to buy an octopus B. inform readers about octopus intelligence C. tell a scary story D. sell aquariums

14. Which is the **best** summary? — A. Octopuses live in the sea. B. Octopuses are highly intelligent invertebrates that solve problems, use tools, and defend themselves cleverly. C. Octopuses have ink. D. Rabbits have neurons.

SCR 2. *(2 points)* Give **one** example that shows octopuses are intelligent. Use **evidence from the passage.**

Paired Set — Recycling

Text A — "Recycle Today" (persuasive)

Our town can do better. Right now, most of our trash ends up in a landfill, where it sits for decades. If we all recycled, we could cut that waste in half. Recycling is simple—start today, and make our community cleaner for everyone.

Text B — "Recycling by the Numbers"

Recycling one ton of paper saves about 17 trees and thousands of gallons of water. Towns with strong recycling programs send far less waste to landfills and often save money on trash disposal.

15. Text A is mainly written to — A. inform with statistics B. persuade people to recycle C. tell a story D. give directions

16. Text B mainly provides — A. an opinion B. facts and numbers about recycling's benefits C. a poem D. a complaint

17. Both texts agree that recycling — A. wastes time B. benefits the community C. is impossible D. harms trees

18. Which specific fact appears in Text B but **not** Text A? — A. recycling is good B. "17 trees" saved per ton of paper C. trash goes to a landfill D. we should start

19. "start today, and make our community cleaner" is an example of — A. a statistic B. a call to action C. a counter-argument D. a definition

20. Text B strengthens Text A mainly by — A. adding a story B. providing facts as evidence C. disagreeing with it D. using rhyme

Revising — "A Coding Club"

(1) Our school should start a coding club. (2) Students could learn to make games and apps. (3) Coding is a useful skill. (4) It could help with future jobs. (5) We would meet in the computer lab. (6) A coding club would be popular.

21. Which sentence could **best** be added after sentence 2 to develop it with a detail? — A. "Coding is fun." B. "For example, members could design a simple phone game by the end of the year." C. "I like computers." D. "Labs have computers."

22. Which transition would **best** begin sentence 4? — A. However, B. In addition, C. Because D. But

23. What is the **best** way to combine sentences 3 and 4? — A. Coding is useful, it helps with jobs. B. Coding is a useful skill that could help with future jobs. C. Useful skill, jobs, coding. D. Coding, useful, jobs.

24. Which sentence **best** states the writer's main idea (thesis)? — A. Sentence 1 B. Sentence 3 C. Sentence 5 D. Sentence 6

Editing — "The Garden"

(1) My grandmother grow tomatoes every summer. (2) Her and I water them each morning. (3) The plants grows taller every week. (4) Their is nothing like a fresh tomato.

25. What change should be made in sentence 1? — A. Change "grow" to "grows" B. Change "grandmother" to "grandmothers" C. Change "every" to "ever" D. No change

26. What change should be made in sentence 2? — A. Change "Her and I" to "She and I" B. Change "water" to "waters" C. Change "them" to "they" D. No change

27. What change should be made in sentence 3? — A. Change "grows" to "grow" B. Change "plants" to "plant" C. Change "taller" to "tall" D. No change

28. What change should be made in sentence 4? — A. Change "Their" to "There" B. Change "nothing" to "no thing" C. Change "fresh" to "Fresh" D. No change

Extended Constructed Response (ECR) — *(10 points)*

Text A, "Recycle Today," argues that the town should recycle more. **Should your community do more to encourage recycling?** Write a multi-paragraph **argumentative essay** that states your position and supports it with reasons and evidence, including evidence from the passages. Organize your essay with an introduction, body paragraphs, and a conclusion, and use correct grammar and spelling.

Answer key with TEKS tags for this bonus test is in the manuscript; score with the Quick Answer Keys method and the ECR/SCR rubrics.